

Tench feed on snails, which graze on periphyton—a mixture of microbial organisms that cling to plants. By reducing the number of snails, tench increase the periphyton biomass.

Future thinking

Relationships between organisms and their environment change from place to place and through time. Global climate change is one example of environmental factors that will increasingly affect animal communities. If tipping points are reached, leading to abrupt environmental regime shifts, animal and plant communities, including food webs, may be badly disrupted. Some changes have already taken place, but one of the challenges of ecological thinking in the future is to forecast others.